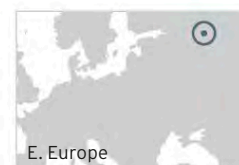




Ferapontov Monastery

Home to the works of a Russian fresco master, the most complete example of a Russian monastic complex from the 15th–17th centuries



Founded by St. Ferapont in 1398, in the Vologda region north of Moscow, Ferapontov became one of Russia's most powerful monasteries under the patronage of the descendants of Ivan III (1440–1505), the first Grand Prince of All Rus. In 1490, Abbot Ioasaf, spiritual advisor to the Grand Prince, rebuilt the original wooden Church of the Nativity of the Virgin in brick and commissioned the renowned artist Dionisy to paint its interior. Covering every wall and ceiling of the church, Dionisy's frescoes remain largely undamaged and richly colored, presenting depictions of an array of miracles, archangels, saints, church fathers, and figures of Christ Pantocrator ("Ruler of All"). The Church of the Annunciation, a refectory, the treasury, and household buildings were added in the early 16th century, and—having survived the ravages of the Time of Troubles (1598–1613)—the monastery grew to include the Church of St Martinian, the gateway church, and a bell tower. With its elegant white facades, tented towers, and onion domes, Ferapontov Monastery provides a beautiful ensemble of the features that dominated Russian architecture from the 15th–17th centuries.

RUSSIAN ROOFS

Onion domes (from the 13th century onward) and polygonal, steeply pitched tent towers (from the 16th century) were common features of Russian church architecture until the late 17th century, and—as shown here—Ferapontov included examples of each. Constructed around a wooden frame, they were invaluable where stone for construction was scarce and useful in preventing the build-up of snow on church roofs.

